

Fleck's Legacy in Kuhn's Historicism

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This chapter offers a historiographically grounded reinterpretation of Ludwik Fleck's influence on Thomas Kuhn's *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions*, arguing that Kuhn's model of paradigms was not only inspired by, but structurally indebted to, the theory of thought styles and thought collectives developed in Fleck's *Genesis and Development of a Scientific Fact* (1935). While Kuhn's later writings acknowledge Fleck only briefly, I argue that the relation runs deeper and can be reconstructed historically through Kuhn's early intellectual formation and archival traces of his engagement with Fleck's text.

Drawing on archival materials, unpublished writings, and Kuhn's annotated copy of Fleck's *Entstehung und Entwicklung einer wissenschaftlichen Tatsache*, I show that Kuhn engaged Fleck early and selectively during the formative phase of his historical investigations into science. The evidence indicates sustained attention to themes that later became central to Kuhn's own framework: the collective organization of knowledge, the pedagogical initiation of scientists, the stability of conceptual systems, and the transformation of scientific frameworks. Kuhn translated Fleck's insight that scientific facts are stabilized within socially bounded epistemic communities into a dynamic, developmental model of scientific change. His paradigms, with their emphasis on normal science, disciplinary education, and revolutionary rupture, may thus be understood as "thought collectives in motion." Whereas Fleck emphasized the stabilization of facts, Kuhn foregrounded the historical transformation of scientific worldviews under communal constraints.

The chapter situates this transformation within the interdisciplinary intellectual environment of mid-century Harvard, where Kuhn's engagement with Fleck intersected with a broader historicist tradition shaped by George Sarton, Alexandre Koyré, and Arthur Lovejoy. In this setting, Fleck's sociology of knowledge did not operate in isolation, but became part of a wider constellation of historiographical and philosophical concerns that informed Kuhn's early development. Kuhn thus appears not merely as a recipient of Fleck's ideas, but as a mediator who reformulated them within a broader historicist account of scientific change.

By reframing *Structure* as a developmental extension of Fleck's sociological epistemology, this chapter reassesses Fleck's place in the historicist turn of twentieth-century historiography of science and argues that his role in Kuhn's formation was more foundational than has generally been recognized.